



MANDAR DEODHAR

states MAHARASHTRA

BULLY BY THE HORNS

In the run-up to elections, Raj Thackeray's goondagiri gets a hand from the Congress-NCP front which hopes to gain from a rift in the Sena



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■ **By Malini Bhupta and Aditi Pai**

It doesn't take much to bring Mumbai to a screeching halt these days. If it's not the rains, the city's notorious goons are always at hand. Statistics show Mumbai witnesses a riot every 18 months, but Raj Thackeray seems determined to alter the score. When news channels started flashing footage of his arrest last Tuesday, schools anticipated riots and declared a holiday even as many people decided to stay home. With 24x7 news channels providing wannabe leaders like him the oxygen of publicity, Thackeray junior has hijacked an archaic agenda and hired goons to

taunt an already ineffective state machinery. And bingo: he's arrived on India's political stage.

It's a script that was authored by his uncle Bal Keshav Thackeray in the 1970s and is now being replicated by the nephew. Rioting, arson and hooliganism have come to define India's financial capital. Raj, who walked out of the Shiv Sena three years ago, would turn many seasoned politicians green with envy by the way he has held an entire state to ransom—with some support from the power centres. What started with beating up north Indian taxi drivers in Mumbai in February this year, has now spread across the state. His fiery, and in some cases, hate-filled

CAUSE & EFFECT:
Raj's arrest triggered widespread arson by MNS workers